



▲ BATTLE OF DAN-NO-URA

Fought at sea, the Battle of Dan-no-ura was a decisive battle of the Genpei War (1180–1185). The Taira clan's defeat ended their control of Japan and led directly to the establishment of the first shogunate under Minamoto Yoritomo.

ARMS AND ARMOR

The weaponry and armor of the samurai was not just key to their military success, but also a symbol of their elite social status. Their main weapons were the deadly *katana* and the shorter *wakizashi* swords, the *tanto* knife used for stabbing, and a long pole weapon called a *naginata*. Since they fought without shields, their armor covered them from head to toe.

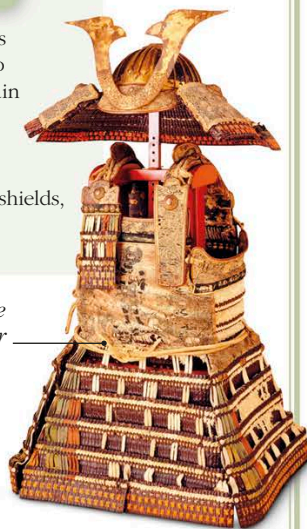
NAGINATA

Breastplate made of iron and leather

TANTO

WAKIZASHI

KATANA



ASHIKAGA TAKAUJI'S ARMOR



◀ SAMURAI CODE

The samurai were strictly bound to the bushido code of conduct, which emphasized the importance of honor and discipline. Samurai who failed to live up to these ideals sometimes took their own lives in a ritual suicide known as seppuku.

SHINOBI ▶

The Shinobi—or ninjas—were another type of soldier in feudal Japan, and were considered socially inferior to the samurai.

These masters of stealth acted as spies and assassins, operating in secret to surprise their targets.

